

STEVEN RITTIE FREEWHEEL HOLIDAYS EDITED

Travel Radio Australia, Travel Radio World. And we're speaking with Stephen Ritty at the moment from Freewheel Holidays from the UK. And Stephen, welcome to the program.

Yeah, thank you. Thanks for having me on. Now, Stephen, you do a whole cycling tour of the UK and tell us a bit about what you do.

Well, we actually do tours throughout Europe. They're all self-guided and we do destinations from as diverse as, say, Scandinavia, down to Italy, Portugal, Spain. But our main core area is Central Europe, Germany, Austria, Poland, and probably Slovenia as well.

Do you go to the Netherlands at all? Yeah, we do. We go to the Netherlands. I actually did a bike and boat tour earlier on in the year, which is a unique concept where you cycle and you go on a river cruise as well.

So it's quite a unique thing and probably quite appealing to Australians and Americans because you get to see so much on one trip. And that's a great thing about the Netherlands. It's so flat and it's so well set up for the bicycles, isn't it? Yeah, it is.

I mean, it's unbelievable. Every signpost is really detailed. You can basically ride around without a map.

It's that good. And also as well, you're riding away from cars, which obviously puts off a lot of people from cycling anywhere. But because the Netherlands is dedicated to cycling, it's part of their culture, it's part of their way of life, there's no reason why anybody couldn't do a cycling holiday there.

Do you just do the normal bikes or do you do electric assist or how does that work? Yeah, I mean, electric bike, so popular now. Before they were a bit of a niche element to a cycling holiday, but now pretty much every booking I do has got at least one electric bike. And you mentioned the Netherlands earlier on, Holland, even though it's flat and smooth, you do have to battle winds and an e-bike just makes you glide along those excellent cycle paths.

Now, how does this all start, freewheel holidays? Tell us a bit about the background. Yeah, so the company has been going for a number of years in the UK since the early 2010s. And it was recently bought by a adventure group holiday specialist based in the Lake District called KE Adventure Travel.

And then I was brought in to run it just after COVID when it was resurrected again as a leading cycling holiday brand. And what's your background personally? Did you have a, were you in cycling racing or how did that work? I've always enjoyed cycle touring. I like the challenge of going to different places by bike.

I've done a lot of cycling holidays myself. I've been to a number of these places that are promoting themselves here at WTM. And cycling is by far the best way of seeing a destination and really getting to understand what a country's like.

I had a dream once of just getting a really nice, powerful electric bike and just taking off from my base in Amsterdam and going around and stopping at places and charging up the bike and keep going. Now, a lot of people do that, right? Yeah, cafes, hotels, they're changing the way that they operate to appeal to cycle tourists now. And yeah, you should do it.

I mean, Amsterdam's perfect. So you can ride down the North Sea coast. You could possibly even head into Germany or even up to the Dutch islands.

So yeah, you're in a good spot for cycle touring for sure. And what are some of your favorite destinations and out-of-the-way places that you've experienced with the cycle tour? I mean, the most popular cycle route in Europe is the Danube Cycle Path, which goes from Passau to Vienna. It's the ideal gateway route for the first time cycling holiday.

But I personally like riding in Scandinavia. We wanna be a specialist in Sweden, Denmark, those countries. I also have had some good times out in Finland as well.

Fat biking, that was a bit of a unique trip. But basically, I just enjoy riding my bike somewhere different. Well, having spent eight years in Sweden myself, living there, I can really relate to that because especially places like Gothenburg, Stockholm, they're so well set up for bikes.

Malmö, they're all beautifully set up. And you can go there and just grab a bike. They have great bike hire schemes there too.

Yeah, they do. I mean, I went to Gothenburg on a cheap Ryanair flight from Manchester not long ago. And the aim was to ride a Swedish cycle route called the Kattegat Cycle Route.

It goes down from Gothenburg to Helsingborg. And I was just astounded at how good it was. You know, riding around the city, following the route notes, GPX files.

To be honest, I hardly referred to them. The signage is that good. And 90% of the route was away from the traffic and was like much better than I thought it was gonna be.

Some of the places that you were mentioning before, Austria and Germany. Tell us about some of the routes there. Yeah, I mean, Germany's probably the best place for long distance cycle touring.

We get a lot of customers coming over from, say, America. Some come from Australia to ride the Elbe and the Rhine Cycle Route. Plus, you've got the Eurovelo routes as well.

So if you are planning a cycle tour in Europe, go to the Eurovelo site first, get some inspiration,

and then head over to one of the cycling holiday companies such as ourselves to make the booking. That's how you do it. And you were telling me you had a group of Australians recently with you.

We did a group tour for a group of friends. They go on a cycle tour around Europe, somewhere new every couple of years. And they decided to ride from Bordeaux to Toulouse.

And a great time. It's a bit difficult logistically to organize because of the time difference. It was on hand to answer any emails and questions that they had.

And they also hired a couple of e-bikes too. One of them actually wanted to hire one whilst they were there because their friend's one was such a good thing to ride. Now, we have some great places in Australia too.

Have you ever been to Australia to cycle around yet? No, but my four-year-old daughter is obsessed with Australia. She loves the Peppa Pig in the Outback episode. So, you know, one day I'd like to take her.

And yeah, we definitely hire a bike if we were in Sydney or Melbourne, for example. Well, Melbourne is excellent for that because it's such a flat city as well. And you can get around really well.

It's got a fantastic bike network system too. And I suppose she's fascinated by our wildlife too. We're like our koalas and kangaroos.

Yeah, yeah, she is, she is. And it's quite funny. She mentions Australia quite frequently.

So I think one day we'll either have to go or move there. Yeah, it's got a little expensive little trip, but nevermind, it's worth it. And it's worth it to see the kids really react to our wildlife.

And there's great places like the zoos where you can actually get right up close to the koalas and the kangaroos and you can pet them as well. It's fantastic. That's good.

Now, how can people find out more, Stephen, about freewheel holidays online? Yeah, just Google us. You know, the website details over 130 tours, all self-guided, e-bikes are available. And also as well, if you want a specific destination that you can't see on the website, just send us a contact form and I can probably turn it around.

Well, happy cycling throughout Europe and Scandinavia, Stephen. It's a fantastic program, freewheel holidays. Look it up online.

And if you're coming to Europe and you want to get on the two wheels, this is a great way to do it. Stephen Ritty, thanks for being on the program. Thanks for having me on.